

August 12, 2026

Cigna Healthcare
Cigna Appeals Unit
P.O. Box 188011
Chattanooga, TN 37422

RE: Formal Appeal of Claim Denial — Loyd Connelly (MRN MUSC5884686), Claim MUSC-20260616-11F2-1

Patient	Loyd Connelly (DOB 1932-06-09)
MRN	MUSC5884686
Member ID / Group	CIG117214019 / GRP-58733
Claim number	MUSC-20260616-11F2-1
Date of service	2026-06-16
Procedure billed	CPT 99223 — Initial hospital care, high complexity
Primary diagnosis	E66.9 — Obesity, unspecified
Denied amount	\$1,786.35
Denial code	CARC 96 / RARC N130 — Non-covered charge(s).
Appeal deadline	2027-02-05

Dear Appeals Review Committee:

SUMMARY OF APPEAL

MUSC Health submits this first-level appeal on behalf of patient Loyd Connelly (MRN: MUSC5884686, Member ID: CIG117214019, Group: GRP-58733) regarding claim MUSC-20260616-11F2-1 for services rendered on June 16, 2026, by Marcus T. Bledsoe, DO (NPI 1770615243). Cigna Healthcare denied the claim in full on August 9, 2026, citing CARC 96 (Non-covered charge(s)) and RARC N130, with the payer remark: "Service is excluded under the member's plan benefit document." The billed charge of \$1,786.35 for CPT 99223 (Initial hospital care, high complexity) remains unpaid. MUSC Health respectfully contends that this denial is not supported by the clinical record and requests immediate reversal and payment at the contracted rate of \$1,108.98.

CLINICAL BACKGROUND

Mr. Connelly is a 94-year-old male with an extensive and medically complex history. His active conditions include chronic congestive heart failure with onset in 2009, Alzheimer's disease, carcinoma in situ of the prostate with ongoing oncologic management, chronic pain, recurrent rectal and colon polyps, and long-standing obesity (E66.9, onset 1963). His current medication regimen reflects the severity and breadth of his conditions and includes intravenous furosemide for heart failure management, extended-release metoprolol succinate, memantine hydrochloride for Alzheimer's disease, docetaxel injection and leuprolide acetate for his prostate malignancy, and a nicotine transdermal patch. The convergence of active cardiac disease, progressive neurocognitive decline, active oncologic treatment, and obesity in a 94-year-old patient represents a high-complexity clinical picture by any standard measure. The service was rendered in an inpatient hospital setting (Place of Service 21), consistent with the acuity and monitoring requirements this patient's conditions demand.

BASIS FOR APPEAL

CPT code 99223 describes an initial hospital care evaluation and management service requiring a medically appropriate history and physical examination, and medical decision-making of high complexity, or total time meeting the threshold for that level on the date of the encounter. Given Mr. Connelly's documented active problem list — which includes congestive heart failure, Alzheimer's disease, active prostate malignancy under treatment, chronic pain, and obesity — the assignment of high-complexity initial hospital care is clinically appropriate and accurately reflects the work performed by Dr. Bledsoe on June 16, 2026.

Cigna's denial categorizes this service as a non-covered benefit exclusion. However, the plan's coverage period is confirmed as January 1, 2024, through December 31, 2026, encompassing the date of service. CPT 99223 is a standard evaluation and management code representing a foundational component of inpatient medical care. Blanket exclusion of an initial inpatient hospital care service for a member with this degree of medical complexity is inconsistent with the plan's obligation to cover medically necessary inpatient services. MUSC Health requests that Cigna identify with specificity the plan benefit document language upon which this exclusion is based, as the denial notice directs only to general benefit documents without citing a specific exclusion applicable to this service or this patient's circumstances. Without a clearly applicable exclusion, the denial does not meet the standard required for a benefit-based denial determination.

REQUESTED ACTION

MUSC Health respectfully requests that Cigna Healthcare overturn the denial of claim MUSC-20260616-11F2-1, recognize CPT 99223 as a covered, medically necessary service for this date of service, and issue payment at the previously established allowed amount of \$1,108.98. Supporting medical records for the June 16, 2026, encounter are included with this submission. Should Cigna maintain that a specific plan exclusion applies, MUSC Health requests that the applicable benefit document language be provided in writing as part of the appeal determination, so that any further review may be conducted with full transparency. This appeal is submitted in advance of the February 5, 2027, appeal deadline via the designated portal in accordance with Cigna's stated appeal submission requirements.

Respectfully submitted,

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Enclosures

- Remittance advice / explanation of payment
- Itemized claim detail (UB-04 / CMS-1500)
- Relevant clinical documentation from the medical record